

Laws before rooms

How game and level designers make a place that reads as a place — and why seven fields drawn art-first kept coming out as pictures of one.

A · THE ORDER DESIGNERS ACTUALLY WORK IN

This is a sequence, not a checklist: each step decides what the next one is allowed to draw.

- 1

Verbs

Write down what the player can **do** — the whole list, usually under ten. Duskers: navigate, open, close, gather, scan, return, dock. A space exists to give the verbs somewhere to happen; a space designed before its verbs is scenery.
- 2

Nouns and the economy

What exists; what is scarce; where it enters (**source**) and where it leaves (**sink**). The economy is what makes a map matter: a room is worth visiting because something in it is spent or gained. Without one, a map is a diagram.
- 3

The information law

What can be seen, from where, and when. Fog of war is a rule about **information**, not a visual effect: Duskers draws nothing a drone's sensor hasn't touched. Decide this before drawing, because it decides how much of the world needs drawing at all.
- 4

The blackout

Grey boxes at real scale, real verbs, no art. Played until it is a place — until a tester can say *I'm in the workshop, the forge is behind me*. Art goes only on what survives the blackout.
- 5

Ship the rule, not the level

Procedural games ship a generator and its laws; the layout is whatever the laws produce from the data. The dungeon README already says it — *the map is a pure function of the reading*. Field 8 is therefore a rulebook and one blackout, not a mockup to copy.

B · WHY "IT IS NOT A SPACE"

Kevin Lynch, *The Image of the City* (1960) — the vocabulary level designers borrowed for wayfinding. A place reads as a place when all five are present and agree.

Paths	The channels you move along. The dungeon's corridors — the one thing field 1 had and nobody else did.
Edges	Where the place stops. Water. The rim of a ring. The fog.
Districts	Regions with one character; you know when you are inside. src/, tests/, the underground.
Nodes	Junctions you travel to and from. The hub. A goal's door.
Landmarks	The reference you orient by, visible from far off. The hub's light. The one running drone.

Diagnosis. The holding (field 7) has districts and nothing else. The pods (field 6) have districts, edges and landmarks but no paths — where did the drone go? The scroll (field 2) has none of the five, which is fine: it never claimed to be a place, it is the HUD.

C · FOUR MORE LAWS DESIGNERS LEAN ON

- The body

There is exactly one thing on screen that is **you**, and it is never lost. In Duskers that is the drones; losing one is the failure state. Field 6's open question — where are the drones — is this law missing.
- Silhouette before label

A thing's kind reads from its shape and colour at a distance, before its name is legible. Amber / ice / black already does this for temperature; the kinds — room, drone, door, goal — still need shapes.
- Diegetic or HUD

Everything drawn is either **in** the world (a room, a drone, a door) or **over** it (fuel, the pack, the console). Decide per element, once. A panel floating in the world is the second reason a screen stops feeling like a place.
- Persistence

The same thing is in the same place tomorrow. Layout is a function of the data, never of the session. The dungeon README states this already; it is a law, keep it.

WHAT BACKWARDS LOOKED LIKE

Draw a field. Judge it by feel. Draw another.

Seven fields, each a full art pass, each rejected on a law nobody had written down: no paths, drones lost, panels standing in the world.

WHAT FORWARD LOOKS LIKE

Write the verbs. Greybox. Play it for a week. Then art — on the one moment that earns it.

Board 3 is the rulebook, board 4 the greybox, board 5 a single rendered moment to test the laws against the eye.

Seven fields, read as one studio

Your own verdicts, sorted by law. The right-hand tags are which of Lynch's five each field actually has — the missing ones are why it "isn't a space".

FIELD	KEEP	DROP	HAS
1 · the dungeon rooms in a hex court, corridors, the hub in the middle	The corridors — the only field with paths. The hub as origin. A closed door = an unresolved need.	The hex court as the whole ground. Rooms are warp items, so the map redraws whenever the work list changes — persistence breaks.	PATHS NODES EDGES DISTRICTS LANDMARKS
2 · the scroll · go-to fuel, the machine card, heddles, the warp list, the cloth by day	Fuel bars. The run card. Heddles as a strip. The cloth's day rule and its produce counts (pr / c / kb) against duration. Verdict: this is the HUD, collapsed — it stops being the main view and becomes what the HUD expands into.	The cloth's filter-chip row — becomes a heddle plus search. Nothing else: a document is allowed to have none of the five.	PATHS NODES EDGES DISTRICTS LANDMARKS
4 · the loom coral tree of files touched, lit by recency; runes; the bench; a cloth strip	The tree as the ground's drawing — the one thing in seven fields that is territory. The runes. The bench as a verb: what you clicked, shown small (a plaque), not a column.	The bench as a panel. The warp as a chat list. The whole right-hand dashboard.	PATHS NODES EDGES DISTRICTS LANDMARKS
5 · four states time scroll, archive tiles, goal boards with rings, the console	The console — the right thing on the right side. The four-state header (quiet · working · the wall · his read) as the field's mood, worn by the whole screen.	Rings as a kanban. The archive as tiles. The time scroll as a strip of dots.	PATHS NODES EDGES DISTRICTS LANDMARKS
5b · one list, four projections the log; P for the pack, with every context block sized	One transcript, projected. The pack expanded on P, blocks with their bytes. Both become laws on board 3.	Nothing. It was never a place and never pretended to be.	PATHS NODES EDGES DISTRICTS LANDMARKS
6 · surface / hub / underground tree above, the hub as a mouth, goals as levels below	Three districts with named roles: the archive, the mouth, the work. The hub as the node the resident stands in between acts.	The underground as a stack of level boxes. The console standing in the world instead of over it.	PATHS NODES EDGES DISTRICTS LANDMARKS
6 · the pods dark water, islands, drones moored at home; the phosphor transition	Water as the edge. Home as the ground the islands moor to. The phosphor trace — on actors only: a drone leaving a wake, never the whole screen.	The whole-screen transition. The deck-per-topic warp as the ground. Stunning, and you cannot say where a drone is.	PATHS NODES EDGES DISTRICTS LANDMARKS
6 · the warp by topic a deck per topic, a lane per distance from the hand	As a projection of the warp, opened from the console with a heddle lit — a view, not a ground.	As the ground. A sorted list is a good list; it is not a map.	PATHS NODES EDGES DISTRICTS LANDMARKS
7 · the holding nested boxes per directory — things · lit · time; operator block; console	The operator block top-left (face, fuel, drones out) — the fuel finally off the top. The console. "N things · n lit · time" as what a room reads.	Nesting as the map. Hypnotic, and a disk-usage scan: districts inside districts, no paths, no drone anywhere.	PATHS NODES EDGES DISTRICTS LANDMARKS

The laws of the field

Verbs, nouns, the economy, the information law, then ten laws the greybox must obey. Where a field already had the law, it is credited; the rest is new.

VERBS · WHAT THE OPERATOR CAN DO

look	pan, zoom – one camera, three named zooms
lift	light a heddle; the ground dims to it
search	type a heddle you have not kept
open	a room, a run, a warp item → the plaque
say	a line to the wire – the light moves
dispatch	send a drone here – stages intent
freeze	open a past run's frame; esc to thaw

Seven. If the greybox needs an eighth, write it here first.

NOUNS · WHAT EXISTS

the ground – repo, kb, dominion: the islands and the home they moor to

rooms – files and directories; a room reads things · lit · last touch

drones – b_.d and its strands; the only bodies

the hub – shed forge wire crew clock belt pack archive: the resident's stations, on the home deck

warp items – what is asked; **cloth items** – what has become

heddles – lenses; **doors** – unresolved needs

ECONOMY

source fuel, refilled by resets
sink runs – a drone out is fuel burning
produce prs · commits · kb pages · replies
The cloth is where produce is read against sink. The fuel gauge is where source is read against time. Neither is a control: dispatch decisions moved into the resident, so the operator watches the economy and steers by saying, not by picking a core.

THE LAWS

- 1

One ground. Everything that exists is somewhere on it. Anything drawn over it is HUD and looks like HUD – a bracketed frame, never a room.
- 2

Light is a visit. Only what a drone touched is lit; light decays over a week; unvisited is black, never dim. This answers how much tree you need: exactly the lit part, and the black silhouette of the rest. (field 4, dungeon README)
- 3

A drone is never lost. Every drone has a position on the ground and a trail behind it at every zoom. Off-map (a cloud seat, a shell somewhere else) is a position too: the edge of the water, with the trail going out. (new)
- 4

Rooms don't move. The layout is a pure function of the reading: the same state draws the same ground. Nothing about the session – camera, lifted heddles, opened doors – is written back. (dungeon README)
- 5

The console is the warp. Everything brnrd did – shell, git, wire, forge, code – is one transcript. Warp items are its asked lines, the run log its doing lines, the cloth its become lines: three projections of one list, never three lists. (field 5b)
- 6

A heddle is a saved search. A search is a heddle you have not kept. Same lens, same rendering: the ground and the transcript dim to what matches. Layers, as in Photoshop – lift several, the union lights. (new)
- 7

The cloth freezes the field. Opening a become-line does not open a page: it freezes the whole view at that run – the ground lit as it was, the drone where it stood, the transcript scrolled to it – inside a frame that says so. Esc thaws. (your flexible run frame)
- 8

The pack is the inventory. Collapsed, it is the last lines and a byte count. On P it is the body: every context block, its bytes, what grew it. It never changes the ground. (field 5b)
- 9

Colour is temperature. Amber is alive, spending, the resident's trace. Ice is the operator's hand and a reading gone low. Black is absent. Shape carries kind: a room is a box, a drone is a bracketed glyph with rings, a door is a gap in a wall, a goal is a rim. (dungeon README, extended)
- 10

The world has a heartbeat. One beat (the daemon's), and it is the only thing that moves unprompted: outlines breathe on it, a drone's rings pulse on it, the phosphor wake is drawn by it. No other ambient motion. (field 4's 600 ms beat, field 6's wake)

THE SIDE QUESTIONS, ANSWERED BY THE LAWS

- Fuel selection is less relevant**

Right, and the economy says why: the operator reads source against time, the resident decides sink. So the fuel is a gauge in the HUD, not a picker at the top. Its expanded state is the scroll's fuel block, opened from the gauge.
- Issue connectors and the warp**

Law 5: a Linear or GitHub issue is an asked line with a foreign door – it opens on the forge, not here. What the warp needs from a connector is small: an id, a title, a state, whose hand it is in, and the door out. Nothing else crosses, and the forge stays the place where it is edited.
- Search versus topic filtering**

Law 6: the same thing. Search is the heddle rail's empty slot. Typing lights a temporary rune; keeping it saves the signature as a topic file. One mechanism, one rendering, no second filter UI.
- The cloth should be search-oriented**

Law 5 + 6 + 7: the cloth is the become-projection of the transcript, so a search lenses it like everything else; a day groups it; a row freezes the field. The chip row goes; a search box and the runes replace it.
- Not just code**

A shell agent's ground is not only the repo. Law 1 makes room for it: the home deck holds what is not a file (the wire, the forge, the clock), and a drone standing on the deck is a drone doing shell work. The transcript records it either way.

HEDDLES · RAIL

1

2

3

4

5

6

/

search = unkept rune · L6

THE FACE + FUEL

HUD

L9

b_.d · state · session ██████ · week ████ · drones out: 1 · click → the scroll's fuel block

MOOD

HUD

quiet · working · the wall · his read — worn by the whole frame, not a tab

THE PACK · COLLAPSED

HUD

L8

last two lines · 645k tokens · 21 blocks · press P →

THE GROUND

WORLD

L1

L2

L4

one camera · interior / mid / schematic · drag, wheel, 1 2 3

ISLAND · SRC/

DISTRICT

drone · rings

door · gap in a
a lit tree: rooms as boxes, only visited wall · an
ones drawn, the rest a black silhouetteunresolved need

L2

room

room

137 things · 58 lit · 18:57

ISLAND · TESTS/

DISTRICT

strand · rings

room

125 things · 48 lit

ISLAND · KB/

black · never visited · silhouette only

HOME DECK

NODE

shedforgewirecrew

clockbeltpackarchive

the resident's stations · not files — shell work happens here

trail · L3 · path

the water — the edge · nothing exists below it · off-map drones sit on the shore, trail going out · L3

THE PACK · EXPANDED ON P

HUD

L8

the body as context blocks, each with bytes; the blocks a run grew are marked; never touches the ground

boot · identity-core.md	6.3 KB
boot · work surface	51.3 KB
boot · dominion digest	21.1 KB
run · read daemon.py	+3.9 KB
run · user · wire	+0.7 KB
...	

boot 148 KB + run 52 KB = 200 KB on the body

a WoW chat when closed; an inspector when open

THE WARP · ONE TRANSCRIPT

HUD

L5

askeddoingbecome

three projections of one list · asked = warp items, incl. foreign issues with a door to the forge · become = the cloth, grouped by day, search first

19:29Z read src/brr/daemon.py:14960 · edit :14965

19:31Z tool forge · PR #2000

19:34Z weave wire → him: stamps not formats

19:40Z edit surface/workflow.md · the drone is on src/ · click a line → the ground jumps there

become-row click → the whole view freezes at that run inside a bracketed frame · esc thaws · L7

say something — or "dispatch src/brr/daemon.py" — the light moves where the act lands

send

solid = "in the world" [] dashed = HUD, "drawn over it" L=numbers cite board 3 · no art on purpose! this is played, not admired

2 / 6 LIT . CLOCKWORK, ADOPTION

```
THE PACK                                645k tokens · 21 blocks · P
19:29Z read daemon.py:14960 · edit :14965 +3.9 KB
19:12Z you · wire · "create a good demo video"
+0.7 KB
```

PLAQUE esc

src/brr/daemon.py

lit 19:29Z · read · edit :14965 · 3
footprints this week

open

dispatch here

THE WARP asked · 55 **doing** become · 12 today one transcript · click a line and the ground goes there 600 ms / beat · 1 2 3 zoom · ? readings

19:20Z **tool** forge · PR #2000 · issue #2001

19:21Z **weave** wire → him: THE WALL THAT COULD NOT READ — fixed on #2000; merge?

19:29Z **read** src/brr/daemon.py grep refill · starvation · thaw

19:31Z **you** wire "how could we make the interface fit the periodic trims"

19:34Z **edit** src/brr/daemon.py :14965 · the drone is here · b·w·d on tests/ · pytest 81 passed

SAY say something — the light moves where the act lands **send**